

streaming films in terms of content that passed the Bechdel test in 2022 versus 2021. The Bechdel test, conceptualised by Alison Bechdel in 1985, is an internationally accepted yardstick to measure gender representation in content. A film is considered to have passed the Bechdel test if it has at least one scene in which two named women are speaking and the conversation is about something other than men. For streaming series, the criterion was modified to include three scenes, given their longer runtime. By this measure, streaming series have done better, with a much higher 55 per cent score.

“While there has been a slow but steady improvement in a few key parameters, there is a need to take a look at inclusion with a serious eye. Streaming continues to pave the way for female representation; however, the sub-par performance of theatrical films should serve as a wake-up call for the industry,” says Shailesh Kapoor, Founder & CEO of Ormax Media.

Things are far worse down South, per Ormax data. Hindi has the highest representation of female HODs across formats. Experts see a direct correlation between more female leaders and better representation of female characters, as well as more women getting hired to do the job. While 17 per cent of HOD positions in Hindi movies and series were held by women, the figure for Telugu was 7 per cent, Tamil 6 per cent, while Malayalam and Kannada were the laggards at 4 per cent each.

According to Kavary Kalanithi Maran, Executive Director at Sun TV Network, even though media is a space where women are the primary consumers, there’s still not enough representation of women in the workforce. “We try to hire in such a way that 60 to 70 per cent of our fiction team is women. But two to three years after joining, many leave to get married. We are still not at that point where men move [relocate for work] for women after marriage,” she explains. She also feels that the shift towards nuclear families is not helping matters. Women are often seen sacrificing their careers for the sake of raising children. “That way, joint families were a good support system where you knew your child would be taken care of. In nuclear families, who will look after your kids? And it’s always the women [who have to leave their jobs],” she says.

HOLDING THE DOOR OPEN

For reasons like these, Jyoti Deshpande, who manages Jio Studios’ 100-plus asset slate that launched in April, says it’s important that women don’t check out after reaching a certain level. “Women also have to put themselves forward to challenging roles,” says Deshpande, President, RIL Media Business. She believes that when



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APARNA PUROHIT
HEAD OF INDIA & SEA
ORIGINALS, AMAZON
PRIME VIDEO



“It matters to me that more women are out there, but you can’t do charity... opportunities should be given to women if they are good at their jobs”

GUNEET MONGA KAPOOR
PRODUCER AND CEO,
SIKKHYA ENTERTAINMENT

the going gets tough, the tough get going. “I would encourage existing women leaders to hire and mentor other women consciously rather than by accident. We have to walk the talk. In my leadership team at Jio Studios we have 70 per cent women leaders who are all at the top of their game,” she says. Deshpande believes having more women will help give voice to women-centric stories. “This is not activism but rather a purposeful shift in the narrative of equality, rather equity,” she says.

Purohit, too, believes it’s important to keep the door open for other women. “Once you have entered the room, you should keep the door open for other women to find their way in. If that had not been done for me, I would not have been here today. When I started working, it wasn’t surprising if I was the only woman in the